MERCY'S ANATOMY

Document MA-007: The Victor Donohue Foundation

Canon Lock v2.1. Institutional dossier as of July 1, 2005

STATUS: LOCKED IN. The Victor Donohue Foundation was founded by **Dr. Victor Donohue** in **1978** and is headquartered in **Boston, Massachusetts**. It is the largest, most successful, powerful, influential, respected, beloved, charitable (it spares no expense) and valuable medical foundation in the world. **Valuation as of July 1, 2005: $300 billion**, and it rises every day.

At a glance (fiscal year 2005)	
Founded	Tuesday, May 30, 1978, on Victor Donohue's 45th birthday
Founder and Chairman	Dr. Victor Donohue (1978-present)
Headquarters	The Donohue Center, 375 Longwood Avenue, Longwood Medical Area, Boston, MA
Motto	*"No one is ever turned away."*
Valuation (endowment)	**$300 billion** (July 1, 2005), rising daily
Charitable spending, FY2005	$18.9 billion (6.3% of assets). The law requires 5%; Victor's rule is 'never the minimum.'
Employees and affiliated staff	about 46,000 worldwide
Active in	118 countries and all 50 states
Legal form	U.S. private foundation (501(c)(3)), with supporting operating organizations
Investment arm	Mercer Capital Management (Boston), which manages the endowment
Colors and emblem	Navy and gold. The emblem is the Donohue Valve, a stylized heart valve inside an open hand.

Not the same as the family fortune. The Donohue family's personal wealth ($200 billion in 2005, MA-005) and the Foundation's $300 billion endowment are **separate**. Foundation assets are irrevocably dedicated to charity: no Donohue can spend them, and the family controls only how they are used, through the board. That separation is real-world law, and it is a constant source of drama.

1. The Founding Story

The night on Route 49 (1958). On a rainy night in February 1958, 24-year-old Dr. Victor Donohue was driving through Mississippi on his way to a conference in New Orleans. A truck had overturned, and a Black sharecropper's eight-year-old son, Elijah Tate, had a crushed chest. Victor drove the boy to the nearest hospital, which refused to admit him through the front door. While the hospital argued over which entrance a Black child could be carried through, Victor operated on Elijah on the loading dock with borrowed instruments and a flashlight. Elijah lived. Victor never forgot the argument at the door, and he spent the next twenty years building a career and a fortune for one purpose: to make sure that no one, anywhere, is ever turned away.

The Donohue Valve (1971). As a cardiac surgeon in Boston, Victor designed and patented a tilting-disc heart valve that lasted longer and clotted less than anything before it. The first implant was on Monday, March 15, 1971. The **Donohue Valve** became the most widely implanted heart valve of the 1970s. Its royalties were the seed of everything.

The founding (1978). On Tuesday, May 30, 1978, his 45th birthday, Victor signed the Foundation's charter at his kitchen table in Brookline. Joan Mercer and their children were at the table, and 19-year-old Natasha signed as the youngest founding trustee. He assigned the valve's patents and a $40 million founding gift to the Foundation, and on the same day he founded Mercer Capital, named for Joan, to grow the money. The endowment reached $1 billion by 1984, through royalties and early bets on biotechnology, imaging and the medical-device boom. It passed $50 billion in 1995 and $300 billion by 2005. Its first employee was Elijah Tate, by then a Jackson, Mississippi, schoolteacher, who served as the Foundation's first Director of Community Health until 1999.

The Founding Covenant

Seven rules, framed in the lobby of the Donohue Center and read aloud at every board meeting:

- **I.** No one is ever turned away.
- **II.** Spare no expense where a life is at stake.
- **III.** Never give the minimum.
- **IV.** Train our own. Build where others will not.
- **V.** Nothing is named for a living Donohue.
- **VI.** The money is not ours. We are only its stewards.
- **VII.** Measure success in people, not dollars.

Covenant V is why nothing in the Foundation carries Victor's grandchildren's names, and why Marc's anonymity has been so easy to protect. Joan insisted that the Mercer name is hers, not a Donohue's, which is how the Mercer Scholars and Mercer Capital exist. She calls it the loophole she's proudest of.

2. Leadership and Governance (2005)

Position	Name	Since / notes
Founder and Chairman of the Board	Dr. Victor Donohue	1978
Trustee	Dr. Joan Mercer	1978. Chairs the Mercer Scholars program.

Position	Name	Since / notes
Trustee	Dr. Natasha Donohue	1978. Founding trustee at 19. Chairs the Ethics Committee.
Trustee	Dr. Victor 'V.J.' Donohue Jr.	1985. Chairs Finance, and is the heir apparent.
Trustee	Dr. Lawrence Donohue	1990. Runs the Children's Hospitals network.
Trustee (Whitmore Seat)	Dr. Lorraine Whitmore	1993. Holds the permanent seat created for Victor's late partner, Dr. Elias Whitmore. It passes to Julian Whitmore in a later season.
President and CEO	Dr. Marguerite Lyle	1999. A former Meharry dean and an operational genius.
General Counsel	Renata Donohue, Esq.	1996
Chief Investment Officer, Mercer Capital	Odessa Brightwater	1988. The quiet reason the endowment compounds.
Independent trustees	Seven seats	Held by leading physicians, a former U.S. Surgeon General-level public health official, and two community members from Roxbury and the Mississippi Delta.

Dr. Marguerite Lyle (born April 2, 1947, Nashville) and Odessa Brightwater (born September 9, 1951, Memphis) are new characters. They'll be added to the cast table (MA-006) when they first appear on screen.

3. The Ten Pillars: What the Foundation Does

#	Pillar	What it is
1	Donohue Children's Hospitals	14 children's hospitals in 2005 (Atlanta, Boston, Chicago, Detroit, Houston, Jackson MS, Memphis, Newark, New Orleans, Oakland, Baltimore, Birmingham, the South Bronx and Kingston, Jamaica). No child is ever billed. Run by Dr. Lawrence Donohue.
2	The Donohue Award for Surgical Excellence	Founded 1979 and called 'the Oscars of surgery.' It carries a gold medal shaped like the Valve and a $5 million prize ($1M to the surgeon, $4M to their hospital). It is given each November in Boston. The first ceremony was on Saturday, November 17, 1979. Winning it makes a career; never winning it haunts one.
3	The Mercer Scholars	Full-ride medical school scholarships named for Joan Mercer: about 4,200 active scholars in 2005. Scholars pledge two years of service in an underserved community after training. Alumni are everywhere, including, quietly, on the Queens Grace staff.
4	The Freedmen's Fund	Endowment grants to historically Black medical schools and teaching hospitals, named for Freedmen's Hospital, where Victor trained. It is the single largest private funder of Black medical education in America.
5	The Jubilee Program	The Foundation buys medical debt in bulk for pennies on the dollar and forgives it, with a letter that says only: 'Paid in full. No one is ever turned away.' It has erased more than $11 billion in American medical debt since 1991.
6	The Donohue Fleet	Mobile surgery: the hospital ship *MV Elijah Tate* (commissioned 1994), six surgical aircraft, and 140 surgical trucks that reach places hospitals don't.
7	The Donohue Institute for Cardiac Innovation	Boston, opened 1983. It produces device and transplant research, and its patents feed back into the endowment.
8	The Global Surgery Initiative	Surgical training and hospitals across West and East Africa, the Caribbean and Brazil. About 2,600 local surgeons trained since 1986.
9	The Donohue Disaster Response Corps	A standing rapid-response medical force: field hospitals, airlift and surge staff. It can deploy within 24 hours anywhere in the world.
10	Mercer Capital Management	The investment arm. It manages the endowment, and it is why the valuation rises every day. The Foundation is legally and ethically walled off from the Donohue family's private investments.

4. Headquarters and Landmarks

- **The Donohue Center**, 375 Longwood Avenue, Boston: a 31-story limestone-and-glass tower in the Longwood Medical Area, completed in 1989.
- **The Valve Room**: the boardroom on the 31st floor, with a round table built around the original 1971 prototype valve under glass.
- **The Mercer Library**: the largest private archive of Black medical history in the world.

- **The Loading Dock**: a preserved concrete slab from the 1958 Mississippi hospital, installed in the lobby in 1998. Every Mercer Scholar touches it on their first day.
- **Donohue House**, Brookline: Victor and Joan's home, where the charter was signed. Family-only.

5. Relationship to Queens Grace Hospital

- **Natasha's Wall (2005):** Queens Grace receives **no** direct Foundation funding. Natasha refuses it, on conflict-of-interest grounds and out of pride: she wants to build something without the Donohue name. Queens Grace staff can still apply for Foundation grants and the Award like anyone else, and Natasha recuses herself from every one of those decisions.
- **Merger pressure (Seasons 5-6):** as Queens Grace nears insolvency, the Foundation offers a rescue. Natasha refuses, and the hospital merges with Hudson Mercy instead.
- **The purchase (Season 9):** after the Season 8 finale crash, the Foundation, together with the surviving doctors, buys the hospital, and the hospital is renamed **Bullock Sloan Memorial** for Grace Bullock and Malcolm Sloan. This mirrors the counterpart arc in which the doctors and the Harper Avery Foundation buy the hospital. Natasha's Wall comes down for good.
- **The Award at Queens Grace:** Donohue Award nominations for Queens Grace surgeons are a recurring storyline, and a minefield for the hidden grandson.

6. Timeline

Date	Milestone
February 1958	Victor operates on Elijah Tate on a Mississippi hospital loading dock.
Monday, March 15, 1971	First implant of the Donohue Valve.
Tuesday, May 30, 1978	Foundation chartered in Brookline; Mercer Capital founded the same day. $40M founding gift.
Saturday, November 17, 1979	First Donohue Award for Surgical Excellence.
1983	Donohue Institute for Cardiac Innovation opens in Boston.
1984	Endowment passes $1 billion. First Donohue Children's Hospital opens (Atlanta).
1986	Global Surgery Initiative begins in Accra, Ghana.
1989	The Donohue Center opens on Longwood Avenue.
1991	Jubilee Program begins.
1994	The hospital ship MV Elijah Tate is commissioned.
1995	Endowment passes $50 billion.
1999	Dr. Marguerite Lyle named President and CEO.
July 1, 2005	**Valuation: $300 billion.** The series begins.
Wednesday, August 31, 2005	Two days after Hurricane Katrina, the Disaster Response Corps lands in New Orleans and the Foundation pledges $6 billion to the Gulf Coast.

7. In the News

In-world press coverage, 2005.

THE BOSTON GLOBE

Wednesday, August 31, 2005, Late Edition

Donohue Foundation Pledges $6 Billion for Gulf Coast

Field hospitals already operating in New Orleans; 'No one is ever turned away,' says founder

BOSTON. The Victor Donohue Foundation pledged $6 billion yesterday for medical relief on the Gulf Coast, the largest single disaster commitment by a private foundation in American history. Its Disaster Response Corps had surgical teams on the ground in New Orleans less than 36 hours after Hurricane Katrina made landfall.

Two field hospitals were operating on Interstate 10 by Tuesday evening, Foundation officials said, and the hospital ship *MV Elijah Tate* was steaming from the Caribbean toward the mouth of the Mississippi.

"We will be there as long as there is a single person who needs a doctor," said Dr. Victor Donohue, 72, who founded the Foundation in 1978. "Nobody waits at the door. Not this time."

The Foundation, valued at about $300 billion, is the largest charitable foundation in the world. It spent $18.9 billion on its programs in the fiscal year that ended June 30.

NEW YORK DAILY NEWS

Saturday, November 19, 2005

Queens Docs Snubbed Again at 'Surgery Oscars'

Queens Grace shut out of Donohue Award for third straight year; Chief stays home

Boston's black-tie Donohue Award gala came and went last night without a single nominee from Queens Grace Hospital. Insiders say that Chief of Surgery Dr. Natasha Donohue, daughter of the Foundation's founder, recuses herself so thoroughly that her own hospital gets no favors, and maybe fewer than none.

"She'd rather lose clean than win dirty," said one QGH attending. "It's very on-brand. It's also very annoying."

This year's $5 million prize went to a pediatric transplant team from Houston.

QueensGraceConfidential (Blogger), posted Sunday, November 20, 2005, 1:14 AM

"Heard in the 4th floor lounge: an intern whose last name rhymes with 'pullback' said the Donohue Award is 'just a really expensive participation trophy.' Bold words for a man who's never been to Boston. Or HAS he??? Stay tuned, Queens." Comments (14).

8. Canon Log Additions

ID	Established fact	Source
C-042	The Victor Donohue Foundation was chartered on Tuesday, May 30, 1978, in Brookline, and is headquartered at the Donohue Center, 375 Longwood Ave, Boston. Its valuation on July 1, 2005 is $300 billion, and it rises daily.	MA-007
C-043	Foundation assets ($300B) are separate from the Donohue family fortune ($200B).	MA-007
C-044	The motto is 'No one is ever turned away.' The Founding Covenant has seven rules, including 'Nothing is named for a living Donohue.'	MA-007 §1
C-045	The Donohue Award (since 1979) carries a $5M prize and is presented each November in Boston.	MA-007 §3
C-046	Natasha's Wall: QGH takes no direct Foundation funding until the Foundation buys the hospital in Season 9.	MA-007 §5
C-047	New characters Dr. Marguerite Lyle (President and CEO) and Odessa Brightwater (CIO, Mercer Capital) will be added to MA-006 on their first appearance.	MA-007 §2
C-048	The Foundation's valuation is tracked as a running figure that rises daily. Every in-story reference must use a figure at or above the last stated one.	MA-007

END OF MA-007. CANON LOCKED (v2.1).
No one is ever turned away.